The Words and *Acronyms.*

A short glossary of the AAC and special education terms you will hear most often. Useful for new staff, for substitutes, and for anyone tired of nodding along without being sure.

AAC and Communication

AAC *Augmentative and Alternative Communication*

Any method a person uses to communicate beyond spoken words. Includes gestures, sign, picture boards, and speech-generating devices.

SGD *Speech-Generating Device*

An electronic AAC device that produces spoken output when buttons are selected. Sometimes called a high-tech AAC system.

Core vocabulary

The small set of high-frequency words used most often in everyday speech. About 80% of what we say uses core words like go, want, more, stop, help.

Fringe vocabulary

Activity-specific or topic-specific words. Less frequent but more concrete. Names, foods, animals, classroom items.

Aided language stimulation

Modeling on the AAC device while you speak. The most evidence-based teaching practice for AAC. Sometimes shortened to ALS or aided language input.

Plus one

A modeling rule. Model one level above where the student is producing. If they use single words, model two-word combinations.

Motor planning

The way a student learns where words live on the device by pressing them in the same location repeatedly. Why we avoid moving buttons around.

GLP *Gestalt Language Processor*

A learner who acquires language in chunks or phrases rather than single words. A growing area of focus in AAC.

Communicative function

The purpose behind a communication act. Requesting, protesting, commenting, greeting, asking questions are all functions.

Presume competence

A foundational AAC stance. Assume the student understands more than they can express. Speak to them at age-appropriate levels.

AAC Apps and Devices

Proloquo2Go

An AAC app made by AssistiveWare, used on iPad. Often shortened to P2G. The app most commonly seen across RUSD.

TouchChat

An AAC app made by Saltillo. Available on iPad and on dedicated devices like the NovaChat.

TD Snap

An AAC app made by Tobii Dynavox. Available on iPad and on dedicated Tobii devices.

LAMP *Language Acquisition through Motor Planning*

A specific AAC vocabulary system used in the LAMP Words for Life app. Built around consistent motor patterns.

IEP and Special Education

IEP *Individualized Education Program*

The legal document that defines a student's special education services, goals, and accommodations.

FAPE *Free Appropriate Public Education*

The federal right of every student with a disability to receive special education services that meet their needs at no cost.

LRE *Least Restrictive Environment*

The legal principle that students should be educated alongside non-disabled peers to the maximum extent appropriate.

AT *Assistive Technology*

Any device or service that helps a student access education. AAC is one type of assistive technology.

AT special factor

A required consideration in every IEP. The team must ask whether the student needs assistive technology, and document the answer.

Accommodations

Changes to how a student accesses learning. Extra time, preferential seating, AAC use during testing. Do not change what is being taught.

Modifications

Changes to what is being taught. Different content, different expectations. Different from accommodations.

Present levels

A section of the IEP describing where the student is currently performing. Includes communication for AAC users.

ESN *Extensive Support Needs*

A program designation for students who need significant special education support. Used in California to describe specialized classrooms.

MMSN *Mild to Moderate Support Needs*

A program designation for students who need less intensive special education support than ESN. Also a California term.

SDC *Special Day Class*

A self-contained classroom serving students with similar special education needs. ESN and MMSN are both types of SDC.

SELPA *Special Education Local Plan Area*

A regional special education governance structure in California. RUSD is part of the West End SELPA.

Roles and Services

SLP *Speech-Language Pathologist*

The specialist responsible for communication services, including AAC evaluation and ongoing support.

OT *Occupational Therapist*

A specialist who supports motor skills, sensory needs, and daily living skills. Often involved in AAC access decisions.

PT *Physical Therapist*

A specialist who supports gross motor and mobility needs. May be involved in AAC positioning or device mounting.

IEE *Independent Educational Evaluation*

A specialized assessment conducted outside the district, typically when a family disagrees with district findings or wants additional input.